Letter to Future Us

Civic Skill: Long-Term Thinking | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 5 (Communicating) & Outcome 4 (Learning) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will dictate or draw a message to their future selves, practising the skill of imagining a future version of themselves and their community — and taking that imagined future seriously.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can imagine what I might be like in the future.
- I can think of something I want to remember or tell my future self.
- I can think of something our class is building now that will still matter later.

MATERIALS

- Envelopes and paper for letters
- Sealing wax or stickers to seal the envelopes ceremonially
- A special box labelled 'DO NOT OPEN UNTIL ___' (set a date 3–6 months away, or end of year)
- Photos of the class from earlier in the program
- Picture book: 'The Imaginary' by A.F. Harrold or 'The Day You Begin' by Jacqueline Woodson

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. OPENER: TIME TALK (5 min): 'Where were you a year ago? Do you remember being three? Can you imagine yourself at ten?' Spend time with the genuine strangeness of time passing. Don't rush to the activity.

2. BOOK READING (6 min): Read 'The Day You Begin.' Focus on: every child in the story was once where they are now, and became someone bigger. 'What do you think the children in this book are like now? They grew, and they kept their memories.'

3. LETTER WRITING (10 min): Each child dictates or draws their letter. Prompt: 'Dear Future Me... Right now I am ___. I want you to remember ___. Something I'm learning is ___. I hope that when you open this, ___.' Educator scribes for those who cannot yet write.

Alternative:

4. SEALING CEREMONY (3 min): Seal each letter ceremonially. 'This is a promise from now-you to future-you. We'll keep it safe.' Place in the box. Mark the opening date on the calendar — something to look forward to.

5. CLOSING: 'Future you is already here — you're making them right now, every day, with what you do and what you care about.'

EXTENSIONS

- Community letter: as a class, dictate a letter to 'the children who will be in this room in five years'
- Add a drawing: 'what I think our class garden/project will look like when we open this letter'
- When the letter is opened: compare predictions with reality — celebrate the accuracy and the surprises equally

ASSESSMENT

- The letter itself is the assessment artefact — content reveals children's sense of time, identity, and future projection
- Note: children who imagine continuity between present and future self are demonstrating a sophisticated developmental milestone
- Observe emotional responses to the sealing ceremony — seriousness, delight, uncertainty — all are worth noting

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Were children able to hold the concept of a future self, or did it feel abstract? What helped?

- What did the content of letters reveal about what children currently value most?
- How does this activity connect to the democratic idea that our choices today affect people who come after us?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 5 (Communicating) & Outcome 4 (Learning). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.